CIS2987 Capstone
Project Proposal
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Prepared for: Virginia Market Square Board of Directors
Date: February 2026
Project Timeline: 6 weeks (March 16 – May 1, 2026)
Investment: Development time equivalent to $8,000–$12,000 value (in-kind donation)

PROPOSAL FOR WEBSITE REDESIGN

Virginia Market Square

Virginia Market Square currently uses Squarespace, which restricts vendor management, limits e-commerce capabilities, and incurs annual fees. This proposal recommends developing a custom website for vendor self-service, direct sales, improved oversight, and lower hosting costs ($120–$265/year), with completion targeted for this six-week capstone project.

The new platform will turn Virginia Market Square into an active marketplace with advanced product discovery, self-service vendor management, and full brand control.

CURRENT CHALLENGES

The current Squarespace website restricts the organization's growth. Vendors must rely on administrators for updates, which causes delays, and the lack of e-commerce tools prevents sales tracking and transaction processing. Limited search features make it hard for customers to find products or vendors. The yearly cost ($200+) is high for a nonprofit, given cheaper, better options.

Additionally, Squarespace limits customization, creates vendor lock-in, and hinders future upgrades, making it unsuited to scaling with the organization or supporting its community.

PROPOSED SOLUTION

Platform Overview

This proposal delivers a professional, full-featured website with three core components: a customer-facing storefront that enables product discovery and purchase, a vendor portal that allows vendors to manage their profiles and products, and an administrative dashboard for organizational oversight.

Customer Experience: Visitors can browse products by category, search across vendors, view detailed product and vendor information, manage a persistent shopping cart, complete a secure checkout process, track orders, and create customer accounts for faster future purchases.

Vendor Empowerment: Vendors access their dashboard to manage profiles, update products and pricing, track orders and sales, and monitor revenue—no technical skills or admin help required.

Administrative Control: Market leadership uses a dashboard to approve vendors, manage data, access site analytics and sales reports, and update market information and events.

Technical Architecture

The website uses a normalized relational database, with separate tables for users, vendors, products, customers, orders, and transactions. This removes data duplication and allows for advanced analytics.

The stack includes HTML5/CSS3 for responsive layouts, Bootstrap for design, JavaScript for interactivity, PHP for server logic, MySQL for storage, and Stripe for payments—reflecting common industry practices.

Security measures include protection against SQL injection and cross-site scripting, password hashing, and role-based access to restrict user permissions appropriately.

Core Features

Capability	Benefit to Organization
Vendor Self-Service	Reduces administrative burden; vendors control their presence; real-time updates
Product Catalog	Customers discover what vendors offer; search and filter by product type
Shopping Cart & Checkout	Direct transaction capability; organization captures sales data; revenue opportunity
Vendor Analytics	Vendors see their performance; informs product decisions; demonstrates value of participation
Order Management	Track transactions; vendor fulfillment coordination; customer communication
Responsive Design	Works on phones, tablets, desktops; reaches customers wherever they shop
Secure Payments	Stripe integration handles card processing securely; PCI compliance managed by Stripe
Complete Ownership	No vendor lock-in; full customization capability; sustainable long-term asset

PROJECT SCOPE & DELIVERABLES

What Will Be Built (52 Development Hours)

Public Website: Responsive homepage with featured vendors and products; category and search-based browsing; vendor storefronts; product details; event calendar; account management; shopping cart; five-step checkout; order tracking; contact forms.

Vendor Portal: Login and authentication; manage profile details, business info, images, and contacts; interface for adding, editing, or removing products and images; dashboard displaying sales metrics; track orders and fulfillment.

Administration Panel: Manage vendor applications, vendors, products, orders, events, content, analytics, and sales reports.

Technical Foundation: Normalized multi-table database, secure authentication for customers, vendors, and admins; advanced SQL analytics; Stripe integration for payments (test/production); email notifications; robust security.

What Is Delivered

- Live website on professional hosting with domain configured and SSL security certificate
- Complete source code repository with documentation
- Database schema documentation with relationship diagrams
- Vendor user manual with screenshots and instructions
- Customer guide for shopping and account management
- Administrator guide for vendor approval and content management
- Sample data pre-populated for demonstration

Project Timeline

Week	Dates	Focus
1	Mar 16–22	Planning, design, database architecture
2	Mar 23–29	Database implementation, authentication systems
3	Mar 30–Apr 5	Product browsing, vendor pages
4	Apr 6–12	Shopping cart, checkout process
5	Apr 13–19	Vendor dashboard, analytics
6	Apr 20–26	Frontend design, payment integration
7	Apr 27–May 1	Testing, optimization, deployment

Launch date: **May 1, 2026**

VALUE PROPOSITION

For Virginia Market Square

This website shifts from a cost center to an asset. Squarespace's $200+ annual fee drops to $120–$265 for hosting, granting the organization full ownership and freedom to customize without vendor lock-in or external contractors. The platform allows for growth, including new vendors, services, or features.

The website showcases the organization’s values and dedication to local producers. Unlike the generic Squarespace site, this custom platform highlights Virginia Market Square’s unique story and commitment to supporting vendors.

For Vendors

Vendors can display products professionally without their own websites. The dashboard offers real-time data on customer interest, sales, and market trends, making participation straightforward and transparent to support vendor recruitment and retention.

For Customers

Customers enjoy a streamlined marketplace that backs local producers. Shopping is simple with easy browsing, filtering, and secure Stripe payments, offering a commercial-grade experience while benefiting the local economy.

INVESTMENT & COMMITMENT

This project is being provided as an in-kind contribution of professional development services, valued between $8,000 and $12,000, which represents a substantial benefit to the organization. The sole financial obligations include annual hosting fees ranging from $120 to $265, with additional enhancements—such as e-commerce features, loyalty programs, or a mobile application—available as optional upgrades in future phases.

The developer agrees to dedicate six weeks, totaling 52 hours, to create a website ready for production. Meanwhile, the organization will offer feedback throughout development, approve the design approach, and provide sample content such as vendor profiles, product descriptions, and images.

NEXT STEPS

The following implementation approach is proposed:

1. **Approval This Week):** Board reviews and approves proposal (Hypothetical)
2. **Kickoff (Week of March 9):** Initial meeting to confirm requirements and design direction (Hypothetical)
3. **Design Review (Week of March 16):** Website wireframes and visual design presented for feedback
4. **Development (Weeks 1–6):** Active development with weekly status updates
5. **Testing & Feedback (Week 7):** User acceptance testing with board and sample vendors

6 **Launch (May 1):** Website goes live on production server

CONCLUSION

Virginia Market Square can modernize its digital presence with a custom platform that supports its values and vendor needs. The new website will lower costs, help vendors, enhance customer experience, and enable sustainable growth. With a six-week timeline and clear scope, this is a strong investment for the organization's future.

We look forward to discussing this proposal and answering questions.

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